

LIFE ON THE FRONT

Daily life in the trenches is either very boring or very dangerous. For many German soldiers, cave-like dugouts lining the trench walls are safe spaces to relax between battles. Meanwhile, above ground, troops use deadly machine guns hidden inside concrete “pillboxes” to fight off enemy attacks.

The dugout

Areas carved from the trench wall where soldiers sheltered from bombs or rested at quiet times were called dugouts. German dugouts were often deeper and better built than Allied ones.

Both Allied and German troops use millions of sandbags to protect themselves from gunfire and exploding shells. Each bag of sand weighs about 40 lb (18 kg).

Card games

Playing cards was a popular way to keep boredom at bay. Toy makers produced cards for the troops decorated with military images, as on this Swiss set.



Soldiers have to rest, make coffee, or take a nap whenever they can, as they never know when the enemy will strike next.

Home comforts

Some German troops built “luxury” dugouts, which were almost homelike, with signs over their doorways that said things like “Home Sweet Home.” A few had two or even three underground levels.



Men use a tin cooking dish to boil water or cook food over small heaters.

Writing and receiving letters reminds soldiers of their loved ones at home.

Rats

There were more rats than soldiers in the trenches. They stole food and spread disease. Both sides used dogs, especially terriers, to hunt the rodent invaders.

